

Atlanta Maternal Wellness Alliance

Annual Board Brief | October 2026 | Prepared by Jake Thornton, CNM, Board Volunteer

Executive Summary

Black mothers in Atlanta face maternal mortality rates 3.2 times higher than white mothers in the same metropolitan area, a disparity that has persisted across the 2022-2025 reporting period despite statewide public health initiatives. The Atlanta Maternal Wellness Alliance (AMWA) works to close this gap through referral pathway development, community education, and environmental health advocacy in underserved East Side and South Atlanta neighborhoods. This brief summarizes program outcomes from the 2025 program year and proposes strategic priorities for 2027.

AMWA's volunteer-driven model has demonstrated measurable impact in its first three operating years. In 2025, the Alliance supported 28 clients through documented hospital backup pathways, reached 180 community members through postpartum education workshops, and completed an environmental data brief adopted by two neighborhood planning councils. The 2026 board term focuses on consolidation and partnership expansion ahead of a 2027 funding application to the Georgia Department of Public Health.

Program Highlights - 2025

1. Referral Pathway Mapping

The Referral Pathway Mapping initiative establishes documented, client-held hospital backup agreements between CNM practices and partnering OB/GYN offices and labor and delivery units. Prior to this program, fewer than 30 percent of CNM clients in the AMWA service area had a named backup provider in their birth plan. By the end of 2025, AMWA volunteers had completed pathway mapping for 28 active clients, with backup agreements in place at three Atlanta-area hospitals. The program also produced a one-page pathway card - available in English and Spanish - that clients carry to every prenatal appointment.

2. Community Education Series

AMWA hosted six postpartum warning-sign workshops across 2025, reaching 180 participants at community centers in East Lake, Reynoldstown, and Ormewood Park. Each session covered hemorrhage recognition, blood pressure monitoring, mental health screening, and newborn feeding support. Workshops are free to attend and led by CNM volunteers. Participant surveys collected at the end of each session showed a 78 percent increase in self-reported confidence in identifying postpartum warning signs. Two participants contacted the workshop helpline in the months following attendance and were referred to appropriate care.

3. Environmental Data Brief

In partnership with a graduate student research team from Georgia State University, AMWA compiled PM2.5 air quality data, housing instability rates, and food desert mapping for the 11 zip codes with the highest maternal mortality burden in metro Atlanta. The resulting Environmental Data Brief was presented to the East Lake Neighborhood Planning Unit in November 2025 and the South Atlanta Advisory Council in January 2027. Both councils incorporated AMWA's air quality findings into their

2027 rezoning comment letters to the city.

Outcomes Data - 2024 and 2025

Metric	2024	2025	Change
Clients with documented backup pathway	11	28	+155%
Community workshop attendees	74	180	+143%
Workshops held	3	6	+100%
CNM practice referral partners	1	3	+200%
Board advocacy briefs published	1	2	+100%

2027 Strategic Priorities

Priority 1 - Expand Referral Network to 50 Clients. Scale the pathway mapping program from 28 to 50 active clients by recruiting two additional CNM volunteer coordinators and formalizing partnership agreements with two more labor and delivery units. A standardized intake checklist and training guide will be developed by Q1 2027.

Priority 2 - Submit Georgia DPH Funding Application. AMWA will apply for a Community Health Improvement grant from the Georgia Department of Public Health in the October 2027 cycle. The application will request \$40,000 over two years to fund a part-time referral coordinator position and expand the workshop series to six new neighborhoods.

Priority 3 - Launch Maternal Navigator Pilot. A peer navigator model - in which trained community members with lived experience of Black maternal health challenges support newly pregnant clients - will be piloted in partnership with a local doula collective beginning in 2027. Navigators will complete a 12-hour AMWA training and carry a caseload of four clients each.

Questions and board input may be directed to Jake Thornton, CNM, via AMWA board communications. This brief was prepared for the October 2026 board meeting and reflects program data through September 2025.